

Q 1 (a) What major events took place during the caliphate of Uthman (RA)? [10]

CAIE Marking Scheme

- Uthman was the third caliph.
- He continued the policy of expanding the Islamic territories. He expanded the state towards the east and in the Mediterranean and crushed many rebellions. Details of areas conquered and rebellions put down could be given here.
- The first Muslim naval fleet was built during the reign of 'Uthman.
- It was 'Uthman who during his term as caliph ordered a full edition of the Qur'an to be made and for this appointed Zayd Ibn Thabit to lead the compilation. He ordered all unofficial copies of the Qur'an to be burnt.
- Some candidates may well discuss that it was because of this action of his and the charge that he had appointed inefficient relatives as governors that his rule caused disquiet and led to several uprisings.
- They could go on to mention the uprisings in Iraq, Kufa and Egypt and say how finally in 35 AH troops from all three provinces arrived at Medina to take their complaints directly to the caliph.

Answer

- Before his martyrdom Hazrat Umar Farooq (RA) made committee consisting 6 most senior companions and instructed them to choose 3rd caliph unanimously. Committee consisted Uthman (RA), Ali (RA), Abdul Rehman bin Auf (RA), Saad bin Abi Waqas (RA), Talha (RA) and Zubair (RA). In 644 AD, Soon after the demise of Umar (RA) they gathered at a place and after discussion and analysis Uthman bin Affan (RA) was selected 3rd Caliph of Islam unanimously.
- The demise of Umar (RA) gave courage to Byzantines; they attacked Alexandria and sacked it. Upon orders of Uthman bin Affan (RA), Amr bin Aas (RA) responded quickly and recaptured Alexandria after defeating Byzantine forces.
- Newly appointed governor of Egypt, Abdullah bin Saad (RA) captured Tripoli and Subetula defeating king Gregory. By the end of 647 AD, North Africa came under Islamic caliphate.
- There was a revolt in Armenia and it slipped away from Muslim control. Amir Muaviah (RA) the governor of Syria assisted by Habib bin Maslamah suppressed the rebellion and retook Armenia.
- People of Azarbaijan also revolted but were given befitting reply by Walid bin Uqbah governor of Kufa and Azarbaijan once again came under the umbrella of Islamic caliphate.
- Abdullah bin Amr governor of Busra assisted by Ahnaf bin Qais, Rabia bin Zaid and Majarah bin Masud advanced in Persia and engaged with remains of Sassanid empire who were causing problems for Muslims. They captured Fars, Seestan, Khurasan, Balkh, Kirman and reached till the borders of present day Pakistan.
- Uthman also initiated Muslim Navy and appointed Ameer Muaviah (RA) as Naval Chief. Abdullah bin Qais and Abdullah bin Abu Sarah were worthy naval commanders who captured Cyprus and Rhodes and also defeated Byzantines in Battle of Masts.
- Uthman also paid attention on internal stability and took some harsh administrative decisions. Egypt was the biggest revenue contributing province of Islamic empire and revenue generation was on decline during the era of Egyptian governor Amr bin Aas (RA). Uthman (RA) replaced him with Abdullah bin Saad who was better economist. Walid bin Uqbah replaced Saad bin Abi Waqas (RA) in Kufa and Abdullah bin Amir replaced Abu Musa Ash'ari in Busra upon demand of people.
- When Islamic empire expanded from Africa to central Asia, from edge of Europe to present day Pakistan, people from different regions, nations and countries accepted Islam and started recitation of Quran in their own dialects. Anas (RA) and Huzaifa (RA) observed some disputed over dialect of Quran and immediately reported to Uthman bin Affan (RA). He appointed Zaid bin Thabi (RA) once again to solve this problem, Zaid (RA) assisted by other companions left no stone unturned and worked on this project with

full dedication. The dialect of Quraysh was decided as the standard dialect of Quraysh and copy was rechecked with Mus'haf-e-Hafsa. Then copies were sent to all provinces of Islamic empire and other old copies were collected and burned.

- Last 6 years of Uthman's (RA) rule were full of chaos and unrest. The revolt was the idea of Jewish conspirators and defeated Persian elements who wanted to take revenge of their humiliation. A Jew named Abdullah bin Saba who camouflaged himself as Muslim, led this revolt and planted seeds of mistrust and against innocent caliph.
- They accused that caliph committed blasphemy by burning down old copies of Holy Quran. They accused that caliph is promoting his own tribe Banu Umayyah and neglecting other tribes. Conspirators added fuel to this accusation by recalling Banu Hashim their old rivalry with Banu Umayyah. Conspirators accused caliph of financial corruption and allotting public land to his relatives illegally.
- Uthman talked to rebels, clarified all confusions offered free and fair trial. Rebels seemed to be moved by this notion and retreated conditionally. On their way back to Egypt they found a messenger carrying an official letter stamped by caliph. Upon reading they got to know that it was an official order of Uthman to governor of Egypt to behead these rebels as soon as they reach Egypt.
- Now the rebels reached Madinah and besieged the house of Uthman and cut down the supply of food and water. Uthman tried several times to make them understand that the letter was fake but rebels did not would not believe in him anymore.
- Ali (RA) asked permission of Uthman to fight rebels and repel them by force but Uthman (RA) replied:  "I do not want to be the reason of Muslims bloodshed in the city of Prophet (PBUH)"
- Ali (RA) other senior companions and wives of Prophet (PBUH) tried to persuade rebels but they were not ready to listen to anyone.
- Muhammad bin Abu Bakr broke into Uthman's house and held Uthman by beard, Uthman said:  "Dear nephew! Your father would not like your behavior if he was alive"
- Muhammad bin Abu Bakr left but some other rebel attacked Uthman, first he chopped off fingers of Naila (RA) who tried to protect the caliph and the he killed Uthman (RA) while he was reciting Holy Quran.

Q 2 (b) Explain why 'Uthman encountered difficulties in the later years of his caliphate and was assassinated. [04]

Points to be Covered

- His appointment of family members in important positions was regarded as favoritism.
- The burning of the copies of the Qur'an to be replaced by the official version prepared by Zaid Ibn Thabit was seen as destroying the word of Allah.
- Yet another reason was that some Muslims questioned his ability to rule as they accused him of financial corruption.
- Write about his assassination when after Uthman had pacified the Egyptians, they were on their way home when they got a hold of a letter supposedly from 'Uthman to the Governor of Egypt to have the leaders of the group put to death on their return. Seeking vengeance they returned and killed him.